at the murderous game of harrying and skirmishing. At the battle of Borodino in September the cuirassiers carried out one of their most famous actions, the capture of the formidably defended Grand Redoubt, but even this was achieved at heavy cost. The grim winter retreat from Moscow completed the destruction of the French cavalry. Most of the horses were slaughtered for food and the remnants of the army that survived the campaign could muster less than 2,000 mounts between them.

With desperate energy, the French cavalry was rebuilt in 1813, but most of the troopers were now ill-trained novices and horses were in short supply. Still, the spirit of the cavalry revived sufficiently for a heroic finale at Waterloo in 1815. Late in the battle, with the tide already turning decisively against the French, Ney threw massed cavalry forward in an attempt to break the British infantry squares. But, charging uphill over muddy ground onto the points of bayonets, the French cavalry were mown down by a combination of cannon and musket fire.



LESSONS OF WAR

In the last resort, Napoleon's faith in cavalry can be seen as excessive. The growth in the size of armies during the Napoleonic Wars meant that an adequate size cavalry arm required a greater number of suitable horses than could readily be found, and those horses needed an often impossible quantity of fodder. On the battlefield, the increasing firepower of artillery and the resilience of well-trained infantry with bayonets fixed tended to nullify the impact of the cavalry charge. By 1815 the bold death-defying cavalryman, with his dash and valour, was already on the verge of obsolescence.

Triumphs and disasters

From his first victories in Italy in 1796, through the glorious campaigns of 1805–1807, and even during the desperate defence of France in 1814, Napoleon's armies won many more victories than they suffered defeats. In the end, however, the continuous British naval blockade and the sheer number of his enemies – principally Britain, Austria, Prussia, and Russia – combined to bring Napoleon's dream to an end at Waterloo.

